

Benito Mussolini`s as a propagator for the second world war.

Introduction

Benito Mussolini was one of the many important characters during world war II. Being one of the founders of the Italian fascist party (Fasci italiani di combattamento) in 1919, which later resulted in the formation of the National Fascist party in 1921, he paved the way for Italy as an ally to a severely aggressive Germany. His rise to power and decisions during the chaotic period of the 1940`s had a great impact on the outcome of the war and the following period after. Even more so with the mutually interested dictatorship Adolf Hitler serving as a catalyst for both Germany and Italy during the war. This essay explains and discusses his rise to power and his development of the fascist party.

Mussolini`s origin and claim to power

Born in Predappio south of Bologna, Mussolini was born into a poor family along his three siblings, where his father was a blacksmith and part time socialist, as well as his mother a schoolteacher. In school Mussolini`s was described as a troublesome child, and establishing this reputation further when he allegedly stabbed a schoolmate and got expelled. Later on he acquired himself a teaching diploma which he utilized for a short period being a schoolmaster, which he later on figured was not the right path for him. Being an avid reader of philosophy on the side he gained insight into the works of philosophers that he agreed with, while simultaneously gaining reputation as a unique and captivating character with great prescence.

(<https://www.britannica.com/biography/Benito-Mussolini>)

In 1902 Mussolini moves from Italy to Switzerland with the intention of avoiding his military service. He works for several newspapers and trade unions, all the while getting deeper into socialism and scheming on how to overthrow European monarchies. His attitude and behaviour therefore got him arrested by the Swiss and transported back to Italy where he was released, only for him to repeat his travel to Switzerland and being arrested a second time. After being released in Italy again he completes his military service. It was after his military service that Mussolini made a short debut as a school teacher. After quitting his teaching job he continued working as an active socialist, gaining more and more attention as an individual among other Italian socialist. (https://it.wikipedia.org/wiki/Benito_Mussolini)

In 1910 Italy colonized Libya, which Mussolini (which for the time being was an anti-war supporter) greatly disagreed with, protested against and got arrested. Some time went by and when the first world war arrived with the necessary disruption of politics, Mussolini recognized this as an opportunity to overthrow the European monarchies that he had previously schemed to overthrow, essentially turning Mussolini into a pro-war advocate. His change of perspective was not popular among the socialists he once were admired by, and he was kicked out of the socialist party. This led to Mussolini feeling alienated to his party`s ideals, leading to his fascination of a unified Italy based on nationality and radical change of ideals. This led to his establishment of fascism. (<https://www.treccani.it/enciclopedia/benito-mussolini/>)

Italy was on the side of the allies in world war 1. Following their sacrifices in the war, the hopes for a sizeable reward were high. Expecting land (especially coastal lines) from Austria, Slovenia, Croatia, Bosnia and Herzegovina. The expectations were however not accurate, receiving only a bit of Austria, and Slovenia. This shortcoming in reward was referred to as the "Mutilated victory" by Italian nationalists. The mutilated victory

led to the Italians feeling unfairly treated, and betrayed by the allies. This allowed for Mussolini to step in and state his solution to the problem in a very similar fashion to Hitler with the naziparty to Germany.

(https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Mutilated_victory)

In late october 1922, fascist demonstrators marched to rome with the intention of claiming the power of Italy from King Victor Emannuel the third. In essence this was fascist party`s way of pressuring the king to appoint Mussolini as prime minister. This is known as the march on Rome. The result was Mussolini being in charge of making a new government, where he would later on establish himself as the first European dictator known as "Il Duce". (https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/March_on_Rome), (#5. Italy through time - the "European Civil War" (1914-1945).pdf, moodle)

Similarities between dictators

Mussolini`s rise to power clearly illustrates the importance of political climates. The tensions of German expansionism and feeling of national disparity from the mutilated victory laid a solid foundation for a desperate attempt at a claim of better fortune for Italy. This was remarkably similar to the history of how Hitler rose to power as well. Both being alienated by the people they once related to. Apart from the political climate serving as a gateway for the ideology of both Hitler and Mussolini, the resemblance of character between the two is very prominent. Both characters gained attention for being gifted with rhetorical prowess and strong presence. One could argue that it is unlikely that their political agenda would have gained the attention needed to flourish without their defining leader characteristics and persona.

Conclusion

The rise of Mussolini`s fascist ideology was successful due to many factors. The main one being the strenous political situation in Italy with weak leadership and the mutilated victory. With inspiration from Germany and an eager leader such as Mussolini the manipulation of his followers was easy, and the rise to power was quick. Sharing many ideals, common enemies, and traits with Hitler, the switch to the tri-partite alliance was imminent. The consequences of Italy joining forces with Germany and Japan can still be found today, and the harm done by the fascist ideals still plague Italy to this day both in cultural and economic scenarios.